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DAILY GIST: THE HINDU

(12/11/2026)

Today at a Glance

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1	Rs 62,370 crore NBS subsidy for Rabi 2026-27	[The Hindu]	GS-III, Prelims
2	CGFMU (Mudra loans guarantee) extended for 5 years	[The Hindu]	GS-III, Prelims
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10	Visa categories cut from 13 to 9	[The Hindu]	GS-II, Prelims
11	Karnataka SLP on SC/ST reservation hike	[The Hindu]	GS-II
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13	Swachh Survekshan 2025-26 results	[The Hindu]	GS-II, Prelims
14	Science: Gravitational-wave astronomy & LIGO	[The Hindu]	GS-III, Prelims

Source: The Hindu, International Edition, 12 November 2026 (e-paper supplied, all 18 pages). The Indian Express was not available for this edition, so every item is drawn from The Hindu.

1. Fertiliser Subsidy Raised 64% for Rabi; FY27 Outgo Overshoots Budget

[The Hindu] | GS-III, Prelims

Context:

The Union Cabinet cleared about Rs 62,370 crore as Nutrient Based Subsidy (NBS) on phosphatic and potassic (P&K) fertilisers for Rabi 2026-27, some Rs 24,418 crore more than last Rabi. Costlier gas and fertilisers after the Iran war have pushed the year's subsidy bill far beyond budget estimates.

Key Highlights:

- **Rabi allocation:** Rs 62,370.02 crore against Rs 37,952 crore budgeted for Rabi 2025-26 - a rise of about 64%.
- **Full-year P&K outgo:** with Rs 41,533.81 crore already given for Kharif 2026, FY27 P&K support crosses Rs 1 lakh crore against a budget of Rs 54,000 crore.
- **Urea pressure:** FY27 budgeted Rs 1.71 lakh crore for all fertilisers (Rs 1.17 lakh crore for urea); total spending may exceed Rs 3 lakh crore.

- **Why:** global prices of urea and LNG (the main feedstock for urea) stayed high after the Iran war; over 70% of the FY27 budget was spent by September (CGA data).
- **Fiscal hit:** economists see the fiscal deficit rising by up to 0.3% of GDP, partly already factored in.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
NBS scheme	Since 1 April 2010; fixed per-kg subsidy on N, P, K and S for P&K fertilisers, announced each season.
Urea	Outside NBS; sold at a statutorily fixed MRP; companies get the difference as subsidy.
LNG and urea	Natural gas is the main feedstock for urea; India imports a large share of its LNG.
CGA	Controller General of Accounts, Department of Expenditure, Ministry of Finance - publishes monthly accounts.
Legal basis	Fertiliser (Control) Order, 1985, under the Essential Commodities Act, 1955.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Keeps DAP and complexes affordable during Rabi sowing; protects farm output amid high food inflation.
Concerns	Budget estimates proved unrealistic; urea's low fixed price worsens N:P:K imbalance (ideal 4:2:1); heavy import and gas dependence.
Data & Evidence	Fertiliser subsidy was cut over 8% in the FY27 budget from Rs 1.86 lakh crore in FY26, only to balloon after the price shock.
Way Forward	Long-term supply contracts and joint ventures abroad; nano-urea and biofertilisers; gradual move of urea to a nutrient-based regime; DBT to farmers.
Probable Question (GS-III)	Geopolitical shocks expose the fiscal fragility of India's fertiliser subsidy regime. Examine and suggest reforms.

Conclusion: The higher subsidy protects farmers in the short run, but India needs supply security and nutrient-balanced pricing so that every global shock does not become a fiscal shock.

2. Credit Guarantee Fund for Micro Units Extended till 2031

[The Hindu] | GS-III, Prelims

Context:

The Union Cabinet extended the Credit Guarantee Fund for Micro Units (CGFMU) for five more years up to March 2031, with a Rs 5,000 crore corpus expected to support Mudra loans worth about Rs 12.6 lakh crore.

Key Highlights:

- **Corpus and reach:** Rs 5,000 crore corpus to back about Rs 12.6 lakh crore of collateral-free micro loans.
- **Mudra scale:** by September 2026, over 60.36 crore loans worth Rs 43.34 lakh crore had been sanctioned under PMMY.

- **How it works:** guarantee cover is given to lenders through the National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company (NCGTC) against default risk.
- **Impact claimed:** the Government credits the scheme with creating a new class of entrepreneurs who were outside formal credit.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
CGFMU	Launched January 2016; managed by NCGTC (under the Department of Financial Services).
PM Mudra Yojana	Launched April 2015; loans for non-farm micro and small enterprises.
Mudra categories	Shishu (up to Rs 50,000), Kishore (up to Rs 5 lakh), Tarun (up to Rs 10 lakh), Tarun Plus (Rs 10-20 lakh).
MUDRA Ltd	Micro Units Development and Refinance Agency - a refinancing subsidiary of SIDBI.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Collateral-free credit for micro units, women and first-generation entrepreneurs; aids formalisation.
Concerns	Small average ticket size, rising NPAs in Shishu loans, and weak post-loan handholding.
Way Forward	Cash-flow based lending via account aggregators, credit scoring for thin-file borrowers, and links to markets (ONDC, GeM).
Probable Question (GS-III)	Evaluate the role of credit guarantees in expanding MSME finance in India.

Conclusion: The extension keeps the Mudra pipeline flowing; the next test is loan quality and enterprise growth, not just loan numbers.

3. Editorial: Milking Power - Overturning the Gokul Dairy Mandate

[The Hindu] | GS-II

Context:

Maharashtra amended its Cooperative Societies Act through an ordinance that lets the State nominate directors with voting rights to large cooperatives. Applied to the Kolhapur District Cooperative Milk Producers' Union (Gokul Dairy), it reversed the board majority won in the October election. The editorial calls this a disturbing use of executive power.

Key Highlights:

- **The election:** a Congress-backed panel won 13 of the 25 elected seats on Gokul's board on October 19.
- **Deadlock:** the chairman's election on October 29 failed for want of quorum (14 members); the administration did not recognise the panel's chairman.
- **The ordinance:** approved on November 4 and promulgated on November 6, it allows five nominated directors, four with voting rights.

- **Outcome:** the 13-12 elected majority became 16-13 the other way when a chairman was elected on November 10; the Bombay High Court declined interim relief.
- **Larger worry:** the editorial sees a pattern of state power overriding member choice in cooperatives, a sector with a Rs 4,000 crore turnover in Gokul's case alone.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
Cooperatives in Constitution	97th Amendment, 2011: Article 19(1)(c), Article 43B (DPSP) and Part IXB (Articles 243ZH-243ZT).
Rajendra N. Shah case (2021)	SC struck down Part IXB for State cooperatives; it survives only for multi-State societies.
Cooperative societies	Entry 32, State List.
Ordinance power of Governor	Article 213; must be laid before the legislature and lapses six weeks after it reassembles.
Ministry of Cooperation	Created in July 2021.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Cooperatives are meant to be member-owned, democratic bodies governed by elected boards.
Concerns	Ordinances used to settle political contests; dilution of the democratic principle in cooperatives; judicial reluctance to intervene.
Committees/Judgments	Vaidyanathan Committee (2005) on cooperative autonomy; Rajendra N. Shah (2021).
Way Forward	Independent State cooperative election authorities, limits on nomination with voting rights, and quick judicial review.
Probable Question (GS-II)	Autonomy of cooperatives is the essence of the 97th Constitutional Amendment. Discuss with recent examples.

IN THE ESSENCE

A cooperative belongs to its members, not to the government of the day. Using ordinances to manufacture majorities hollows out cooperative democracy; autonomy, transparent elections and limited state nomination are the safeguards worth defending.

4. Editorial: Visions of the Future - Booker Prize and the AI Anxiety

[The Hindu] | GS-IV, Essay

Context:

The Booker Prize went to M. John Harrison's science-fiction novel The End of Everything. The editorial reads the award as a sign of society's unease about artificial intelligence and the erosion of shared, verifiable meaning.

Key Highlights:

- **Knowledge glut:** AI tools let bad actors flood research and public spaces with doubtful claims, making reliable meaning scarce.
- **The novel:** an alien invasion that defies understanding becomes a metaphor for a 'post-meaning' world.
- **Recognition for sci-fi:** a belated win for a genre Harrison helped shape since the late 1960s.
- **Critique:** the editorial says the novel lets technology and power off the hook, and that praising a book merely for being 'human' reflects AI anxiety.
- **Market hype:** speculative valuations of AI firms can narrow the space for society to debate competing futures.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
Booker Prize	For a novel written in English and published in the UK/Ireland; prize money of GBP 50,000.
International Booker	Separate prize for fiction translated into English; shared equally by author and translator.
Banu Mushtaq	Won International Booker 2025 for Heart Lamp (Kannada; translated by Deepa Bhasthi).

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Ethical dimension	Truthfulness, epistemic responsibility and the duty not to pollute the information commons.
Concerns	Erosion of attention spans; misinformation; concentration of AI power in a few firms.
Way Forward	Public deliberation on AI's role, AI literacy, labelling of synthetic content and accountability for deployers.
Probable Question (Essay/GS-IV)	"In an age of machines that write, meaning becomes a public good." Discuss.

IN THE ESSENCE

The danger of AI is not only false information but the loss of a shared sense of what is true. Keeping open a public space to debate the future - rather than letting markets or machines decide it - is the real task before democracies.

5. Lead: Tamil Nadu's Growing Industrial Water Challenge

[The Hindu] | GS-III, GS-I

Context:

Tamil Nadu ranks among India's top investment destinations, but the writers (Madras Institute of Development Studies) warn that limited water and weak water governance could undermine its industrial future.

Key Highlights:

- **Scarce endowment:** with average rainfall of 960 mm and much of the State in the rain shadow of the Western Ghats, it has only about 3% of India's water resources.
- **Groundwater stress:** extraction is about 73.5% of extractable resource State-wide, but Salem, Vellore and Chennai are over-exploited; Krishnagiri and Coimbatore are critical.
- **Rising demand:** industrial water demand is projected to grow from 1,555 MCM (2001) to 1,985 MCM by 2050.
- **Governance gaps:** the groundwater Act was repealed in 2013; a new water resources Bill (2026) awaits the Governor's assent; the department's allocation was cut by about 8%.
- **Prescription:** price industrial water by local scarcity, scale ZLD, desalination and sewage reuse with green energy, and make water part of investment planning.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
NITI Aayog Investment Friendliness Index	Released July 2026; Tamil Nadu ranked third after Gujarat and Maharashtra.
Groundwater categories (CGWB)	Safe (<70% extraction), semi-critical (70-90%), critical (90-100%), over-exploited (>100%).
Water Act, 1974	Water (Prevention and Control of Pollution) Act - basis for closure orders on polluting units.
Zero Liquid Discharge	Treats effluent so that no liquid waste leaves the unit; used in Tiruppur textile clusters.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Water security is now a factor in investment decisions and industrial competitiveness.
Concerns	Localised over-extraction, river pollution in western Tamil Nadu, high ZLD costs for small units, legal vacuum on groundwater.
Data & Evidence	Tamil Nadu's FDI peaked at USD 3.68 billion in 2024-25; 28 units received closure orders under the Water Act in June 2026.
Way Forward	Scarcity-based pricing, mandatory recycling, groundwater law, and treating water as infrastructure to be built and paid for.
Probable Question (GS-III)	Industrialisation without water planning is unsustainable. Discuss with reference to water-stressed States.

IN THE ESSENCE

Tamil Nadu does not need more water so much as better management of what it has. Pricing water for its scarcity, recycling it, and governing groundwater by law will decide whether its industrial growth lasts.

6. Op-Ed: Turning Battery Waste into Strategic Mineral Wealth (with DGFT ban on black mass exports)

[The Hindu] | GS-III, Prelims

Context:

The same day the DGFT barred exports of lithium-ion battery black mass, an op-ed by Shyamasis Das (Centre for Social and Economic Progress) argued that end-of-life batteries should be treated as a strategic domestic source of critical minerals.

Key Highlights:

- **Policy move:** DGFT has prohibited, with immediate effect, exports of battery waste and scrap containing Li-ion black mass, so that it is recycled and refined in India.
- **Strategic context:** critical minerals such as lithium, nickel and cobalt have concentrated supply chains, and China dominates processing.
- **Informal leakage:** informal recyclers recover only 10-20% of materials versus over 90% in formal facilities.
- **Potential:** with over 8.7 million EVs on roads by FY26, recycling could meet about 10-12% of lithium demand for EV batteries.
- **Five-point strategy:** recycled minerals in the national stockpile, R&D in recovery, quality standards, easy take-back for EV users, and patient capital for recyclers.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
Black mass	Powder from shredded Li-ion cells containing lithium, nickel, manganese, cobalt and graphite.
DGFT	Under the Ministry of Commerce and Industry; Foreign Trade (Development and Regulation) Act, 1992.
Battery Waste Management Rules, 2022	Introduced Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) and recovery targets.
National Critical Mineral Mission	Approved January 2025; covers exploration, processing and recycling.
18th BRICS Summit	Held in New Delhi in September 2026.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Builds a circular economy, processing capacity and a buffer against supply shocks.
Concerns	Low current volume of spent batteries, under-utilised plants, varied chemistries, weak collection.
Way Forward	Mandated recycled share in the stockpile; design-for-recycling; buy-back schemes by EV makers; concessional finance.
Probable Question (GS-III)	Urban mining can be a pillar of India's critical-minerals security. Examine.

IN THE ESSENCE

The EV transition should not end when a battery leaves a vehicle. Keeping black mass at home and building formal recycling early can turn a waste problem into a modest but strategic source of critical minerals.

7. Opinion: How the Algorithm is Being Targeted

[The Hindu] | GS-II, GS-III

Context:

An opinion piece argues that content blocking on social media has scaled up sharply and that the government is now also seeking to influence platforms' recommendation algorithms, raising due-process concerns for free speech.

Key Highlights:

- **Scale of takedowns:** nearly 1.95 lakh blocking orders were sent to Instagram, Facebook and YouTube between March and July - roughly one every 68 seconds.
- **Sahyog portal:** lets Ministries, States and police send takedown requests directly; since February, platforms have three hours to comply.
- **Algorithm as target:** MeitY asked Meta in October to review ranking systems to avoid 'disproportionate exposure' to limited narratives.
- **Due process gap:** a down-ranked post gives the user no notice to challenge, unlike a blocked post.
- **Demands:** publish every order with issuer, date and grounds; users should contest wrongful takedowns.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
Section 69A, IT Act, 2000	Power to block online content; Blocking Rules, 2009 provide for reasons and review.
Shreya Singhal v UoI (2015)	Struck down Section 66A; upheld Section 69A because of its procedural safeguards.
Sahyog portal	Run by the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), MHA.
Karnataka HC, Sept 2025	Dismissed X Corp's challenge to the Sahyog mechanism.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Online platforms are now the main public square for youth mobilisation.
Concerns	Opaque orders, no hearing, compressed timelines, chilling effect, and invisible 'shadow' down-ranking.
Judgments	Shreya Singhal (2015); Anuradha Bhasin (2020) on proportionality of restrictions.
Way Forward	Transparency reports, reasoned orders, independent review, and algorithmic audit standards.
Probable Question (GS-II)	Balancing online safety and free speech requires procedural, not just substantive, safeguards. Discuss.

IN THE ESSENCE

The legitimacy of content regulation rests on reasons, notice and review. Whether a post is blocked or quietly buried, citizens deserve to know who acted and why; transparency is what keeps regulation from becoming censorship.

8. Opinion: Reset the Tax on Transfer of Property

[The Hindu] | GS-III

Context:

Two economists argue that Tamil Nadu's high stamp duty and registration fee (SDR) encourages under-declaration and yields less revenue than lower-rate States, and suggest reforms for its new Revenue Augmentation Committee.

Key Highlights:

- **Revenue weight:** SDR formed 11.7% of States' own tax revenue in 2024-25; Tamil Nadu 11.3% vs Maharashtra 14.8% and Karnataka 12.3%.
- **Rate paradox:** Tamil Nadu levies 9% total SDR against 6% in Karnataka and Maharashtra, yet collected about Rs 22,000 crore versus Rs 24,000 crore and Rs 50,000 crore.
- **Guideline values:** official values lag market prices; the writers want annual, data-driven revision by an autonomous committee.
- **Registration fee:** should be capped as it is a service charge, as Maharashtra does at Rs 30,000.
- **History:** partial reforms after 2002 more than doubled SDR revenue in four years.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
Stamp duty rates	State List Entry 63 (except instruments in Union List Entry 91).
Indian Stamp Act, 1899 / Registration Act, 1908	Central laws governing stamp duty and registration of documents.
GST and real estate	Stamp duty on immovable property remains outside GST.
Laffer curve	Beyond a point, higher tax rates can reduce revenue by encouraging evasion.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	SDR is a key own-source revenue for States after GST subsumed many taxes.
Concerns	Under-valuation, black money in property deals, and high transaction costs that deter a resale market.
Way Forward	Lower rates, capped fees, spatial analytics for guideline values, and incentives to declare true prices.
Probable Question (GS-III)	Rationalising stamp duty can raise both compliance and revenue. Examine.

> **IN THE ESSENCE**
>
> *Lower, simpler property-transfer taxes and realistic guideline values can raise more revenue than high rates that invite evasion. Good tax design rewards honest declaration.*

9. Explained: Supreme Court and the OBC Creamy Layer Test

[The Hindu] | GS-II, Prelims

Context:

On November 6 the Supreme Court reaffirmed its March 11, 2026 judgment that parental salary and agricultural income cannot alone decide OBC creamy-layer status, while clarifying that completed selections need not be reopened.

Key Highlights:

- **March ruling:** upheld the 1993 DoPT Office Memorandum: the test is status-based (category of parent's post), not purely income-based.
- **2004 letter:** a clarificatory letter cannot add a substantive condition absent in the 1993 framework.
- **No reopening:** past selections, promotions and cadre allocations are not disturbed; pending claims can be decided on the March principles.
- **CSE 2025:** the ruling applies to service allocation of OBC candidates from CSE 2025, as allocation was not yet final.
- **Timeline:** the Centre's plea for two years to frame PSU-government post equivalence was rejected; compliance time was extended by two months.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
Indra Sawhney (1992)	Upheld 27% OBC quota; introduced the creamy-layer exclusion and the 50% ceiling.
DoPT OM, 8 Sept 1993	Lays down creamy-layer categories; salary and agricultural income excluded from the income/wealth test.
Income limit	Rs 8 lakh per annum (since 2017).
Rohini Commission	Article 340 commission on sub-categorisation of OBCs; report submitted in 2023.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Restores fairness for OBC candidates whose parents work in PSUs and private firms.
Concerns	Lack of PSU-government post equivalence; litigation delays; uncertainty for candidates.
Way Forward	Notify equivalence quickly; periodic review of the income limit; publish the Rohini report.
Probable Question (GS-II)	The creamy layer concept ensures reservation reaches the truly backward. Discuss its implementation challenges.

IN THE ESSENCE

Creamy-layer exclusion should measure real social advancement, not a single salary figure. Applying the 1993 framework consistently, while protecting settled appointments, balances fairness to claimants with administrative certainty.

10. Visa Regime Simplified: Categories Cut to Nine, Forms Leaner

[The Hindu] | GS-II, Prelims

Context:

The Ministry of Home Affairs has simplified India's visa regime, reducing main categories from 13 to nine and making application forms 65-70% shorter, after studying visa systems of developed countries.

Key Highlights:

- **Fewer categories:** main categories cut from 13 to nine and sub-categories from 49 to 23 (August 2026 decision).
- **Visitor Visa:** the Tourist Visa is renamed Visitor Visa with sub-types V-1 and V-2, reflecting wider permitted purposes.
- **Experts:** a special provision has been introduced for subject-matter experts.
- **Leaner forms:** required fields reduced by 65-70%; new system to apply by year-end after IT upgrades.
- **Earlier round:** in October 2025 categories had been cut from 22 to 13; e-visa is available to nationals of 172 countries.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025	Consolidated law on entry, stay and exit of foreigners; replaced four older Acts.
e-Visa	Processed through electronic travel authorisation (ETA).
Nodal Ministry	Ministry of Home Affairs (Foreigners Division).

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Ease of travel boosts tourism, business, academic and medical visits - soft power and services exports.
Concerns	Security vetting must not be diluted; IT transition risks.
Way Forward	Reciprocal facilitation, wider e-visa coverage and faster processing for talent visas.
Probable Question (GS-II)	How can visa policy serve as a tool of economic diplomacy?

Conclusion: A simpler visa regime is low-cost reform with high returns for tourism, trade and India's global image.

11. Karnataka Moves SC Against Quashing of SC/ST Quota Hike

[The Hindu] | GS-II

Context:

Karnataka has filed a Special Leave Petition in the Supreme Court against the High Court's October 12 ruling that struck down the increase in SC reservation from 15% to 17% and ST from 3% to 7%, which took total reservation to 56%.

Key Highlights:

- **HC verdict:** held the 2022 Act unconstitutional for breaching the 50% ceiling; Sections 3 and 4 struck down.
- **Basis of hike:** recommendation of a commission headed by retired judge H.N. Nagamohan Das.
- **Existing matrix:** 15% SC, 3% ST and 32% OBC - totalling 50%.
- **Ninth Schedule push:** the State wants the law placed in the Ninth Schedule; the Assembly passed a resolution in December 2025.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
50% ceiling	Laid down in Indra Sawhney (1992); extraordinary situations as exception.
Ninth Schedule	Added by 1st Amendment, 1951 (Article 31B); I.R. Coelho (2007): laws added after 24 April 1973 open to basic-structure review.
Tamil Nadu's 69%	Protected via the 76th Amendment, 1994 (Ninth Schedule).
Special Leave Petition	Article 136.
EWS quota	Upheld in Janhit Abhiyan (2022), allowing breach of 50% for EWS.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Tests the rigidity of the 50% cap amid demands for proportional representation.
Concerns	Need for quantifiable data on backwardness and inadequate representation; risk of competitive quota politics.
Judgments	Indra Sawhney (1992), M. Nagaraj (2006), Jarnail Singh (2018), Maratha quota case (2021), Janhit Abhiyan (2022).
Way Forward	Robust caste-wise data, sub-classification, and periodic review of quota benefits.
Probable Question (GS-II)	Is the 50% ceiling on reservations still relevant after the EWS judgment? Critically examine.

Conclusion: The case may reopen the debate on whether the 50% ceiling is a constitutional limit or a flexible rule that yields to evidence.

12. Tamil Nadu May Seek Stronger Powers for Cauvery Authority

[The Hindu] | GS-II, GS-I

Context:

Frustrated that the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) cannot enforce its orders, Tamil Nadu is considering moving the Supreme Court to give the authority powers similar to the Bhakra Beas Management Board (BBMB).

Key Highlights:

- **Non-compliance:** Karnataka did not comply in five of seven 15-day release spells ordered since July 29.
- **Deficient year:** four Karnataka reservoirs received about 132 tmc ft (June 1-November 4), a shortfall of about 54% against a 288 tmc ft average.
- **At Biligundlu:** Tamil Nadu received 53.43 tmc ft, about 13 tmc ft short even of a pro-rata share; it puts the backlog near 17 tmc ft.
- **BBMB model:** a Union-appointed board that owns, operates and regulates projects and schedules releases jointly.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
CWMA	Set up in 2018 under Section 6A of the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956, after the SC's February 2018 verdict.
Article 262	Parliament may bar courts' jurisdiction over inter-State river water disputes.
BBMB	Constituted in 1967 under the Punjab Reorganisation Act, 1966; serves Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan, HP, Delhi, Chandigarh.
Biligundlu	Inter-State measuring point on the Cauvery at the Karnataka-TN border.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Enforcement capacity determines whether tribunal awards bring peace or prolonged litigation.
Concerns	Distress-year sharing formulas, political resistance, and absence of penal powers.
Way Forward	Clear distress-sharing rules, real-time data, and a body with operational control over key reservoirs.
Probable Question (GS-II)	Why do inter-State river water disputes persist even after tribunal awards? Suggest institutional reforms.

Conclusion: An authority without enforcement powers turns every deficit monsoon into a dispute; institutional design must catch up with the award.

13. Swachh Survekshan 2025-26: Navi Mumbai Adjudged Cleanest City

[The Hindu] | GS-II, Prelims

Context:

President Droupadi Murmu presented the Swachh Survekshan 2025-26 awards. Navi Mumbai was ranked the cleanest city, followed by Surat and Vijayawada, while Indore did not figure among the top three.

Key Highlights:

- **Top cities:** Navi Mumbai first, Surat second and Vijayawada third.
- **Category winners:** Ujjain (3-10 lakh population), Greater Visakhapatnam (10 lakh-plus), Puri (coastal), Rudrapur (Himalayan) and Rewa (riverfront).
- **Participation:** over 4,751 cities took part.
- **Method changes:** greater weight on citizen feedback in the 2025-26 edition.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
Swachh Survekshan	Annual survey under Swachh Bharat Mission-Urban; Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs; since 2016.
SBM-Urban 2.0	Launched 2021; goal of 'Garbage Free' cities.
Navi Mumbai	Planned city developed by CIDCO in Maharashtra.

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Competitive ranking has pushed cities on segregation, processing and public toilets.
Concerns	Legacy dumpsites, capacity of small ULBs, exclusion of informal waste-pickers.
Way Forward	Decentralised composting, waste-picker integration and stronger municipal finances.
Probable Question (GS-II)	Assess the role of competitive federalism in improving urban sanitation.

Conclusion: Rankings motivate cities, but lasting cleanliness depends on scientific waste processing and empowered local bodies.

14. Science: Gravitational-Wave Astronomy Enters its Statistical Era

[The Hindu] | GS-III, Prelims

Context:

A decade after the first detection, upgraded LIGO, Virgo and KAGRA detectors now record hundreds of black-hole mergers, letting scientists study populations rather than single events and test Einstein's general relativity.

Key Highlights:

- **Clearest signal:** GW250114 (January 2025) came from two black holes of about 34 and 32 solar masses, 1.3 billion light-years away.
- **Einstein holds:** an analysis of 168 signals found no disagreement with general relativity; GW250114's 'ringdown' matched predictions.
- **Mass puzzles:** more black holes near 10 solar masses than expected; only about 15% spin rapidly - pointing to several formation pathways.
- **Pair-instability gap:** a study places the lower edge of the predicted black-hole mass gap near 44 solar masses.
- **India's role:** a sixth observatory of the global network is being built in India.

Prelims Corner:

Term / Fact	Details
Gravitational waves	Ripples in spacetime predicted by Einstein (1916); first detected in 2015 (GW150914); Nobel Physics 2017.
Chirp and ringdown	Rising-frequency signal before merger; fading oscillations of the final black hole.
Detector network	LIGO (Hanford, Livingston - USA), Virgo (Italy), KAGRA (Japan), GEO600 (Germany).
LIGO-India	Approved in 2023; at Aundha, Hingoli district, Maharashtra (DAE and DST).

Mains Facts:

Dimension	Key Points
Significance	Opens a new window on the universe complementing optical and radio astronomy.
Challenges	Detector sensitivity limits; need for global coordination and next-generation observatories.
Way Forward	Timely completion of LIGO-India to improve sky localisation; build Indian expertise in precision instruments.
Probable Question (GS-III)	Discuss the scientific and strategic significance of LIGO-India.

Conclusion: Gravitational-wave science has moved from single discoveries to population studies, and LIGO-India can give the country a seat at this frontier.

Quick Revision: 10 Prelims One-Liners

1. Rabi 2026-27 NBS outlay: Rs 62,370 crore; FY27 P&K support has crossed Rs 1 lakh crore against a Rs 54,000 crore budget.
2. CGFMU (launched January 2016) extended to March 2031 with a Rs 5,000 crore corpus; managed by NCGTC.
3. Defence Ministry signed a Rs 498.58 crore contract with Cochin Shipyard to refit INS Betwa (Brahmaputra-class frigate), shifting it from steam to diesel propulsion.
4. CCEA approved Rs 3,230 crore for a national museum in North and South Blocks; first gallery (theme: adornment) due in late 2027.
5. DGFT has prohibited export of Li-ion battery black mass.
6. India's visa categories cut from 13 to 9; Tourist Visa renamed Visitor Visa (V-1, V-2).
7. Swachh Survekshan 2025-26: Navi Mumbai cleanest, followed by Surat and Vijayawada.
8. Ninth Schedule laws added after 24 April 1973 can be tested on basic structure (I.R. Coelho, 2007).
9. CWMA was created under Section 6A of the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956.
10. Bundibugyo strain is behind DR Congo's worst Ebola outbreak (over 11,000 cases); no approved vaccine exists for it.

5 Practice MCQs

Q1. Consider the following statements:
1. Urea is covered under the Nutrient Based Subsidy scheme.
2. Natural gas is the principal feedstock for urea manufacture.
3. The Fertiliser (Control) Order, 1985 is issued under the Essential Commodities Act, 1955.
How many of the above are correct?
(a) Only one (b) Only two (c) All three (d) None
Answer: (b) - 2 and 3 are correct; urea has a statutory MRP outside NBS.

Q2. With reference to cooperatives, which of the following is/are correct?
1. The 97th Amendment inserted Article 43B.
2. In Rajendra N. Shah (2021), the SC upheld Part IXB in full for State cooperatives.
Select the correct answer:
(a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2
Answer: (a) - The SC struck down Part IXB provisions for State cooperatives; they apply only to multi-State societies.

Q3. The Cauvery Water Management Authority was constituted under which law?
(a) River Boards Act, 1956 (b) Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956 (c) Environment (Protection) Act, 1986 (d) Dam Safety Act, 2021
Answer: (b) - It was set up under Section 6A in 2018.

Q4. Consider the pairs (Detector - Country):
1. KAGRA - Japan
2. Virgo - Italy
3. GEO600 - France
How many pairs are correctly matched?
(a) Only one (b) Only two (c) All three (d) None
Answer: (b) - GEO600 is in Germany.

Q5. In Shreya Singhal v Union of India (2015), the Supreme Court:
(a) Struck down Section 69A of the IT Act (b) Struck down Section 66A and upheld Section 69A (c) Upheld Section 66A (d) Struck down both 66A and 69A
Answer: (b) - 69A survived because of its procedural safeguards.

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